Opening Night

Written by

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Block B

INT. BACKSTAGE OF THEATER - DAY

ANNA (14), taller than the other 9th grade girls, walks with a giddy excitement looking for someone.

Entering the green room, her excitement fades quickly as she takes in the scene unfolding in front of her.

A group of her classmates stand together facing MOLLY (14), Anna's best friend since the 2nd grade. The group, a mix of both boys and girls wearing cool clothes, snicker as Molly, wearing her black under-costume spandex, passionately argues.

MOLLY
Without the trees, Katie wouldn't be able to tell her mark from a piece of gum on the stage. Mr. Kessler says that we play foundational roles!

As Molly speaks, Anna makes eye contact with one of the "cool" kids. She smiles weakly and waves, they ignore her. Anna quickly walks over to her friend who is now stretching. Molly spots Anna.

MOLLY (CONT'D)
(In an announcer voice)
ARE YOU READY?! SPRING MUSICAl '26!!

Molly starts dancing. Anna laughs and joins her.

Their dancing is interrupted by BARRY who barrels straight into Molly looking very sick. In the commotion, Anna steps back and is yanked into the shadows by a mysterious boy.

CUT TO:

INT. DARK VOID (BLACK BOX THEATER?) - CONTINUOUS

DAVID (14), stands encompassed in shadows. He is wearing all black clothes, a BEANIE, and a HEADSET.

ANNA
What the hell? Who are you?
(looking around)
Where are we?

DAVID
SHHHHH. There isn't time for questions! My name is David.

ANNA
What do you want?

DAVID
Barry won't be going on tonight and Mr. Kessler needs you to take over.

David kneels down holding out a tattered, yellowing robe and a fake beard. He bows his head. Anna looks at it in awe.

ANNA
Mr. Kessler sent you? H-he wants me?

DAVID
Yes. And he is awaiting my return...

Anna hesitates, looking back in the direction in which she came, thinking of Molly.

DAVID (CONT'D)
Anna, Mr. Kessler needs you.

Anna smiles.

ANNA
I'll do it. I can't let him down. To the dressing room!

Anna takes the costume from David and leaves. David backs slowly into the darkness.

DAVID
(whispering)
I will always love you Anna Parker...

CUT TO:

INT. BACKSTAGE OF THEATER - CONTINUOUS

Anna steps back into the commotion, hiding her new costume. She helps Molly up.

MOLLY
Ugh! Barry is such a dingus!

ANNA
Y-yeah he is. Molly I need to t-

MOLLY
He thinks he's sooo cool drinking those protein shakes-
(yelling)
WELL HOW COOL ARE YOU NOW!

ANNA
Yeah, um, he's pretty sick and they need a replac-

MOLLY
Oh! When do we wanna do our ritual, it would be bad juju to miss it on opening night.

ANNA
The ritual...right. We'll do it after we get ready, okay?

MOLLY
Ugh, I should go before everyone shows up. Why do we have to share makeup when KATIE gets her own dressing room. I break out every year...

Molly walks off. Anna sighs in relief.

CUT TO:

INT. DRESSING ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Anna ties the robe around her waist and re-adjusts her beard. She looks at herself in the mirror when she hears a knock.

Anna ducks behind the changing room curtain. Molly enters and starts looking around.

MOLLY
Anna? Have you seen my branches?..

ANNA
Um, no I haven't!

MOLLY
Are you almost ready? We're running out of time.

ANNA
Don't come over here! I just need a second...um, puberty stuff...

MOLLY
Oh-okay yeah... Just come find me once you're ready.

Molly leaves empty handed. Anna cautiously comes out from behind the curtain. Suddenly, the door swings open.

Molly, wearing her trunk costume and face paint, walks back in. Molly stares at a speechless Anna.

MOLLY (CONT'D)
Why are you wearing that?

With no response from Anna, Molly turns and runs. Anna follows.

CUT TO:

INT. HALLWAY - CONTINUOUS

Anna follows Molly into an empty hallway where Molly finally stops.

MOLLY
Why didn't you tell me?

ANNA
I'm sorry...I was just scared.

MOLLY
SCARED? THAT'S SUCH BULL! WHAT ARE YOU SCARED OF?

ANNA
YOU MOLLY! Y-you make fun of the main cast all the time. How they dress, what they talk about. You are so mean!

MOLLY
THEY'RE ASSHOLES ANNA! Complete assholes! I thought you agreed, I mean, you used to.

ANNA
We aren't the same person Molly! I don't think you know me at all. I mean, does getting this role make me an asshole to you?

MOLLY
You want to be in the main cast, why?
(MORE)

MOLLY (CONT'D)
So you can wear booby tops and talk to boys. It isn't about the part! When you start going to the main cast party and get a boyfriend and stop talking to me, that's what's gonna make you an asshole!

Molly and Anna go silent and look at each other, eyes wet with tears. The silence is interrupted by David.

DAVID
It's time.

Anna and Molly break their eye contact and follow him inside.

CUT TO:

INT. BACKSTAGE OF THEATER - CONTINUOUS

Anna and Molly stand on opposite sides of the stage wings.

Molly heads backstage, determined to reach Anna. Anna does the same. Meeting in the middle, they look at each other, smile, and jump into their pre-show ritual. They laugh and fall silent.

MOLLY
...Does this mean I've been promoted to Tree #1?

ANNA
I guess so.

MOLLY
You look really good by the way. The beard really ties-

ANNA
-Yeah it frames my face surprisingly well...

Molly hugs Anna. They run back to their spots in the wings.

Anna spots David in the shadows and hugs him. They stand next to one another watching as Molly, wearing her full tree costume and holding her head high, takes her place on stage.

Molly and Anna lock eyes, they smile.

The curtains open.

END.